THE LEGION LETTER
The Royal British Legion
Paris Branch



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Chairman's Report October 2008

If that was the Summer that never was, then this "season of mellow fruitfulness", particularly beautiful this year, is some sort of consolation. If there is an apparent lull in most Legion affairs during the seasonal break the welfare function recognizes no such interval. Cases were being handled during August, and in September, at the instigation of our Welfare Officer, Ron Glen, we held a training session in Paris to which case-workers from the other RBL branches in France were invited. The theme was how to operate as a case-worker in the French context. The issues discussed included the sources of welfare funding, the provision of medical care, the social security system, and taxation. It was generally agreed that the initiative was worthwhile; old hands were able to share their hard-earned knowledge and experience, and those case-workers who were relative novices were extremely grateful for the opportunity to pick the brains of the seasoned campaigners. We agreed to keep in close touch with each other. The event was also marked by the active participation of our guests from SSAFA, whose cooperation with us in the field is much appreciated by our own case-workers.

Since we commemorate this year the 90th Anniversary of the Armistice our Service of Remembrance at Notre Dame de Paris will have a special poignancy. Our Chaplain, Rev Philip Mounstephen, has invited a most interesting guest to give the sermon. David Banbury is a T.A. chaplain who was called up to serve at Basra Airport, where he ministered to both the gravely wounded and the dying. We shall listen to his witness with keen attention. In addition Ken Davey has kindly managed to obtain the services of what many regard as one of the best pipers in the British Army, Lt Colonel Murdoch Macleod. A Drummer from the Coldstream Guards will play the Last Post and Reveille.

Our party has just returned from the visit to the battlefields of Monte Cassino, where we were guided by Colonel Oliver Warman, late Welsh Guards. Our Secretary Janet Warby has filed her trip report on page 4 below.

We congratulate our President, Gyles Longley, CBE, MC on his 90th Birthday which he celebrated at the end of September. We congratulate Jock Miller on the publication of his book, « The Millionaire's Flying Club », which is the subject of the poster on page 7 in this Newsletter.

"We will remember them"

Roger Thorn

SECRETARY'S CORNER

We hope you all had a good summer and enjoyed seeing family and friends or just being able to relax.

As you will see in this Newsletter we have been busy organising the forthcoming Coffee Morning in aid of the Earl Haig Benevolent Fund, Poppy Appeal. You will also see an item on how the Poppy Appeal came into being; I do hope you enjoy reading this.

Anyone wishing to attend the Coffee Morning at the Ambassador's Residence must write, enclosing a stamped addressed envelope, to Joan Hicks before 31st October. Gentlemen do not forget this is open to you as well as the Ladies; we hope to see you on 6th November.

After the summer holidays of course we have to get back to paying subscriptions and bills, we at the RBL are no different. Our financial year begins on 1st October and as Mark Yates, our Membership Secretary mentions, the subs has not increased – about the only thing that has not I can hear you say.

Just as we went to print last time we heard of the death of a former Vice-Chairman, Standard Bearer and Parade Marshall, Alwyn Seppings. Alwyn was a staunch member of the Paris Branch and always had a cheery smile and story to tell. We offer our sincere condolences to his wife Doreen and family.

You will also see an article for a new book written by our Member David 'Jock' Miller on his experiences as a Test Pilot. We can highly recommend this book.

We are in the process of organising the annual ceremony at Notre Dame Cathedral on November 11th. We hope that we will see as many of you as possible at this moving tribute to those who paid the ultimate sacrifice. The Ceremony starts at 15h00, all those wishing to attend must be in place by 14h30. We should not forget that the work of the Legion goes on, not just for those who fought in two World Wars, but also those in our Armed Forces who have fought in subsequent conflicts, and for the widows/widowers and children left behind.

And finally, you will see a brief account by myself of the joint RBL/Oxford Society Battlefield Trip to Monte Cassino. If you have never been it is well worth taking the effort to go.

We look forward to seeing you at some of the events planned.

Janet Warby	Joan Hicks	Mark Yates
Hon. Secretary	Social Secretary	Membership Secretary

EARL HAIG POPPY APPEAL 2008

LADY WESTMACOTT, wife of H.M. Ambassador to France,

has kindly accepted to host a Coffee Morning

in aid of the Poppy Appeal

which the ROYAL BRITISH LEGION, PARIS BRANCH,

organizes every year for the benefit of the

EARL HAIG BENEVOLENT FUND

The Coffee Morning will take place at

THE BRITISH AMBASSADOR'S RESIDENCE

39 rue du Faubourg St. Honoré,

PARIS 8éme

THURSDAY 6th NOVEMBER, 2008

10h30 - 12 noon

Please send your stamped addressed envelope to :
Miss Joan Hicks
6 rue des Petits Prés
78810 Feucherolles

An invitation card for presentation at the entrance will be sent to you. This event is free of charge. Donations welcome. I.D. Cards or Passports required. Numbers limited. Date limit 31/10/2008

MONTE CASSINO BATTLEFIELD TOUR



We have just returned from the RBL/Oxford Society Monte Cassino Battlefield Tour. We had as our guide Col. Oliver Warman, (Retired) who always gives a very good tour and puts forth the history of the tours he takes so that simple folk, like me, can understand and envisage what it must have been like for those who fought in the various battles.

Our first stop was Salerno British War Cemetery where we found the grave of Captain W.R. Follit, The Queen's Own Royal West Kent Regiment. Captain Follit died on 16th September, 1943, he was the cousin of our President, Gyles Longley. There our Chairman, Roger Thorn, laid a Poppy Wreath and recited the Exhortation. Like all Commonwealth War Graves, this one was immaculate.

We arrived at our hotel in Gaeta somewhat tired and reflecting on what we had seen in a short space of time.
Gaeta was the base for the Papal Fleet, which took part in the battle of Lepanto, something many of us did not know. It is now a fairly prosperous town with fishing one of its main sources of income as well as tourism.

The second day of our tour took us along the Garigliano River to get a perspective of the problems faced by the soldiers trying to reach Monte Cassino. We had to go along the Appian Way which, for my husband, who is fanatical about ancient Roman history, was a dream come true. In the winter of 1943/44, the Allies found themselves confronting the Gustav Line, which crossed Italy south of Rome. It crossed Route 6, the Rome-Naples highway, which ran on to Rome along the Liri Valley. The entrance to the Liri valley was dominated, then as now, by the great bulk of Monte Cassino which is crowned by an ancient Benedictine Abbey. We were taken to various spots where the battles were fought (there were four battles for Monte Cassino) before actually taking the ruins of the Abbey at Monte Cassino which had

been destroyed by allied bombing. We had an expert driver who managed to negotiate the hairpin bends, only once did he cross himself. Unfortunately we could not go up the right hand side of the mountain pass to get to the top of Snakeshead Ridge, which is where the Polish Monument is situated, due to the size of our bus. So after negotiating a three point turn we went down the Mountain Pass; not for the faint hearted but good fun all the same. We passed Castle Hill, which we learnt the Gurkhas had taken. Once we managed to reach the Abbey at the top of Monte Cassino, I and another lady in our group went up to the Abbey. The rest went to the Polish Cemetery and were planning to climb to the top of Snakeshead Ridge, to the Polish Memorial. Unfortunately the gates to the cemetery were due to close and so it was decided to return on our last day for those who wanted to climb to the top. We then took a trip to find the French Cemetery some way outside of Cassino. We arrived only to find that on Saturdays the gates close at 13h00.

Sunday morning saw us checking out of our hotel and returning to Monte Cassino. About 8 of us decided we wanted to attend Mass in the Abbey. The Abbey Church is magnificent, some might say over done, I did not see it that way. After Mass we walked around the ground and got an excellent view of the Liri Valley and also of the Polish Cemetery and Monument. The rest of our group returned to the Cemetery and walked up to the Monument. On meeting up with us we then went on our way to the airport in Naples. You really have to visit and see the almost impossible hills and rock formation the Allied Troops had to overcome to dislodge the occupying forces at Monte Cassino. Some might say a waste but it was necessary to do this to safeguard allied armies advancing up the Liri valley towards Rome. Reconstruction and decoration works, on the Abbey itself took more than a decade and were exclusively financed by the Italian State.

I would like to thank Roger Thorn, Arthur Hohler and Oliver Warman for taking the effort and time in planning this trip. I am sure the rest of the group agrees with me. Thank you Gentlemen, we appreciate all you did for us.

Janet M. Warby

How The Poppy Appeal Began

We are often asked how the Poppy Appeal came to be our National Emblem of Remembrance. Once again as Remembrance tide looms, I have looked in two publications about The Royal British Legion and can inform young and old of the origins of the Poppy Appeal.

Poppy Day is essentially cosmopolitan in origin. The inspiration came from across the Atlantic: a Canadian medical officer serving in France had written a poem sitting on the step of the ambulance outside his dressing station on the banks of a canal during the Second Battle of Ypres in 1915. An American woman seized on the leading idea in that poem and applied it (in a sense) in the United States. A few years later a French woman made an unannounced visit to Legion Headquarters in London, from which the Poppy and Poppy Day was born.

The Canadian was Colonel John McCrae who had already served and survived the Boer War. He called his poem 'In Flanders Fields'. It begins :

In Flanders Fields the poppies blow
between the crosses, row on row

and concludes with the stirring lines :

If ye break faith with us who die
We shall not sleep, through poppies grow
In Flanders Fields.

The poem was published anonymously in Punch magazine in December 1915. Among those affected by the verses was a young American woman, Miss Moina Michael. Receiving a gift of ten dollars, she used it to buy twenty-five artificial poppies from a store in New York, she persuaded some of her friends and colleagues to wear these poppies at a conference of YMCA overseas workers in November 1918.

In August 1921 a French woman, Madame Anne Guérin marched into Legion Headquarters with some samples of artificial poppies which were made in France to support her charity, a joint French-American organization seeking to help restore the areas in France devastated by the war. She met with Colonel Crosfield, later Chairman of the Legion from 1927 – 1930, and the General Secretary. She showed them some of the small artificial poppies of the type made in France. Would not the Legion care to adopt the idea as a method of raising money for its own purposes? There were, she told them, two firms in France ready to supply the material. In return she wanted a certain percentage for her own organisation in France.

After much anxious deliberation, it was decided first to consult Sir Herbert Brown, Chairman of the Appeals Department of the Officers Association, and for a time of the Legion's Appeals Department, and then to despatch him to Paris to investigate, reporting on his return that at least the suppliers were genuine. He was then asked to return to

Paris to place an order for one and half million poppies. To this Colonel Heath, General Secretary, told Sir Herbert Brown, 'For goodness sake order three million, whatever else you do.' In the end, according to the Legion Journal of December 1921, nine million were supplied. The first suitable occasion for a poppy-linked appeal would be Armistice Day - 11th November 1921 – which was the chosen date.

The first Poppy Appeal was so successful that the NEC's thoughts turned to future Appeals. It then took steps to register the design of the poppy to prevent the sale of unauthorised sale of imitation poppies. Above all, arrangements were then made to manufacture poppies in the UK.

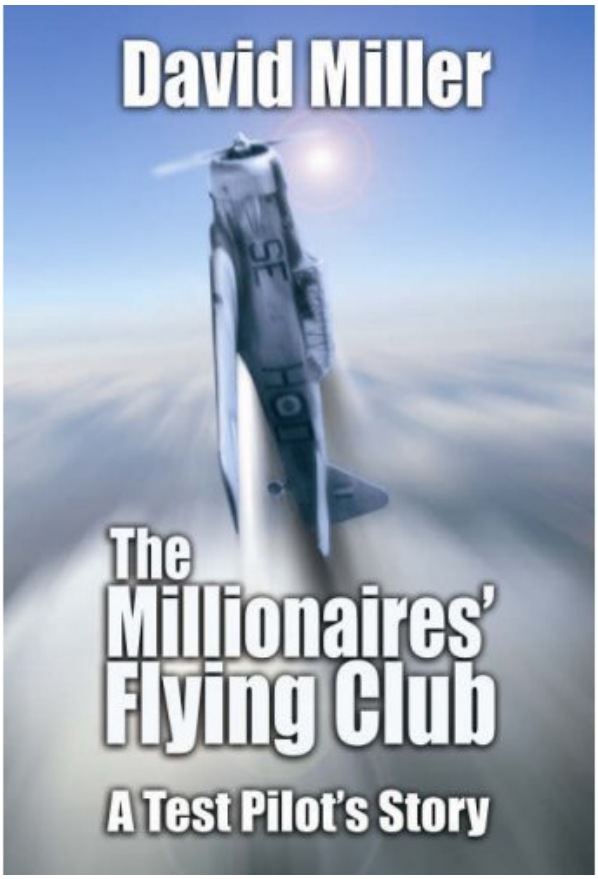
Major George Howson, after the war, launched the Disabled Society. He approached the Legion in due course with the suggestion that the Disabled Society should manufacture poppies for them. This was agreed and having already gone into the artificial-flower trade to gain experience, Major Howson set up a factory, under the Legion umbrella, in a small workroom just off the Old Kent Road, (South-East London). The enterprise began with a staff of five badly disabled ex-Service men, three of whom were still employed in 1954. There were about 330 others working in more pleasant and spacious surroundings of Richmond Hill (Surrey). These men worked a five day week and were expected to produce 1,000 poppies per day each. All the men had either single or double amputations and some travelled some distance to get to work, but they worked with a cheery disposition singing along to the gramophone as they made their poppies. It is thought that by 1924/25 the factory had moved to Richmond Hill from The Old Kent Road. A disused brewery donated by a well-wisher was converted into a factory and an adjoining estate purchased by the Legion, to erect flats for the workers and their families, together with a club. By this time the employees had risen to 190 with well over 300 on the waiting list.

By setting up their own arrangements for the manufacture of poppies the Legion had of course turned its back on Madame Guérin and the organization which had supplied not only the original idea but the means of putting it into effect. The same thing was to happen in Canada, which had also been visited by the enterprising Frenchwoman, but which turned to the local 'Vetcraft Industries' to make poppies from 1925 onwards. There is no evidence of any protest from the original manufacturer, but at the time no legislation existed to prevent the Legion appropriating the idea from another country. In any case as has already been mentioned the National Executive Council had by now patented the poppy buttonhole in the United Kingdom.

Who would have thought that from a poem written by a Canadian Colonel and two inspirational and dynamic women, we would still be wearing the poppy each Armistice Day on November 11th. Had the timing been different, we could have been wearing the poppy on 4th August, the day we entered the First World War.

If you would like to read more about the formation of The Royal British Legion, please let either the Chairman or myself know. We have in our possession two books written on the history of the RBL from which the information you have just read has come. The first book is called 'The Official History of The British Legion' by Graham Wootton published in 1956 and the second is called 'Keeping Faith, The History of the Royal British Legion' by Brian Harding published in 2001.

 Janet Warby Hon. Secretary.



Our member Jock Miller has written a book about his experiences as a test pilot. He has contributed a dedicated copy to the RBL which you can consult at Rue Boudreau.

More details about the book? Click here

Better still buy it. It's on Amazon. Check it out by clicking here:

http://www.amazon.co.uk/Millionaires-Flying-Club-David-Miller/dp/1906302073/ref=sr_1_1?ie=UTF8&s=books&qid=1224089368&sr=1-1

Pay up, pay up and pay the same…

October is with us again. Leaves are beginning to fall from the trees and bills onto the doormat. and, yes, the good news is that your Royal British Legion Paris Branch subscription due on 1st October, has once again remained at a modest €46 or €37 if you are 65 or over, a category which I entered myself this year with some foreboding.

Writing this letter always takes me back to my second job when, for three years, I was a tax collector. The first demand we used to send out was in black ink, the reminder blue and the final reminder red, I remember. Afterwards it got a bit hairy but we won't go into that.

Anyway, this year I have found a unique, one off argument which will surely convince you all to come up with the goodies in record time. I am currently in between two hip operations and will be back in hospital sometime in November and more or less *hors de combat* as far as sending out cards and so on for a period of several weeks.

Thus I would really appreciate it if you would make a special effort to send in your subscription before the end of October so that I can send out your membership cards in good time.

Should you lose the subscription form you can now download another from the rblfrance.org website. You can also get a membership application form should any of your friends wish to join us.

Almost half our membership now have email addresses and I would like to take this opportunity to remind you to let me have yours if you have acquired or changed one during the year. May I remind you that Paris Branch Newsletter can now also be consulted online. If the internet version of the Newsletter suits you, please let me know (by email) and I shall send you the link as and when new issues come out. If you prefer the paper and ink version – or if the online version is delayed for some reason - you will , of course, continue to receive it by post.

You can send any information to mfyates@gmail.com or to paris@rblfrance.org which is our official email address. Our website can be consulted at http://www.rblfrance.org/ Don't forget; you can also check events etc. on the site.

Subscription forms are included with this newsletter. I look forward to hearing from you all soon.

Mark Yates
Membership secretary

Bonne nouvelle.

Le mois d'octobre approche encore. Les feuilles tombent des arbres et les factures sur le paillasson. Mais la bonne nouvelle, c'est que votre cotisation à la Royal British Legion Paris Branch, due pour le 1re octobre, reste inchangée : €46, ou €37 si vous avez 65 ans ou plus, (catégorie que je rejoins moi-même cette année avec une certaine trépidation).

Ecrire cette lettre me rappelle toujours mon deuxième travail en Angleterre. J'étais percepteur d'impôts pendant trois ans. La première demande, je me souviens, était en encre bleu, la deuxième en encre noire et le troisième en encre rouge. La suite, n'en parlons pas.

Toujours est-il que cette année j'ai trouvé un argument imbattable pour vous convaincre de la nécessité de régler votre cotisation au plus vite. Je me trouve actuellement entre deux interventions chirurgicales à la hanche et je rentre à l'hôpital en novembre, en principe, pour la deuxième de celles-ci. Je serai donc plus ou moins hors combat (vous m'excuserez l'anglicisme) pendant un certain temps en ce qui concerne l'envoi des cartes etc.

Ainsi, j'espère que je peux compter sur vous pour régler votre abonnement avant la fin octobre afin que je puisse vous envoyer votre carte en bonne et due forme.

Presque la moitié de nos adhérents disposent maintenant d'adresses e-mail et je profite de cette occasion pour vous rappeler de nous communiquer la votre si vous en avez fait l'acquisition ou si vous l'avez modifiée, au cours de l'année dernière.

Le "Newsletter" de RBL Paris peut maintenant se consulter en ligne. Si vous êtes intéressé pour recevoir la version électronique, faites-le nous savoir (par e-mail) et je vous enverrai le lien dès que la nouvelle édition apparaîtra. Bien sûr, si la version électronique n'est pas prête à temps ou si, simplement, vous préférez la version sur papier, vous continuerez à la recevoir par la poste.

Pour toute demande de "Newsletter" par e-mail ou pour nous notifier des changements d'adresse, d'adresse e-mail, etc. vous pouvez me contacter à mfyates@gmail.com ou à paris@rblfrance.org , cette dernière étant notre adresse officielle attachée à notre site web que vous pouvez consulter à http://www.rblfrance.org/

Vous trouverez ci-joint le formulaire d'adhésion à remplir et à renvoyer avec votre abonnement 2008-09.

A bientôt...

Mark Yates
Membership secretary

THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION PARIS BRANCH

Poppy Appeal et Cotisations 2008/09
POPPY APPEAL & SUBSCRIPTIONS 2008/09

- Normal / *Normale* 46 Euros
- Reduced / *Réduite* (65 and + / *65 ans et* +) 37 Euros
- 25 years and under / *25 ans ou moins* 21 Euros

Poppy Appeal contribution

Contribution au "Poppy Appeal" .....

Annual subscription
Cotisation annuelle .....

Donation to the Administrative Fund
Don aux fonds administratifs .....

Donation to maintenance appeal
Don aux fonds de rénovation .....

TOTAL .....

Name / Nom .....

Address / Adresse .....

.....

e-mail ……..

Please tick the box below if you require a fiscal receipt and, if so, enclose a stamped addressed envelope.

Veuillez cocher la case si vous désirer un récépissé fiscal et, dans ce cas, joindre une enveloppe timbrée à votre attention.

☐

Please make your cheque payable to the "Royal British Legion".
Veuillez établir votre cheque à l'ordre de "Royal British Legion"

Royal British Legion. 8 rue Boudreau 75009 PARIS . Tel 01 47 42 19 26
Website : **http://www.rblfrance.org/** e-mails : **paris@rblfrance.org**